

Tokenomics: How Your CEO Learned That AI Isn't Actually Free

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There's a special kind of executive who evolved and discovered artificial intelligence roughly twenty-four months ago and has not shut up about it since. You know the type. He runs a mid-sized company that manufactures, let's say, industrial adhesives. He struggles to open a spreadsheet without assistance. But last quarter he stood in front of the entire company, adjusted his lapel microphone, and declared that "AI is the electricity of our generation."

Everyone clapped. Someone made a slide. The slide had a brain on it, glowing, for reasons no one questioned.

This is the mania phase, and it is beautiful to witness. The non-technical CXO becomes a guru overnight. He forwards LinkedIn posts. He uses the words "AI" and "agentic" in meetings every now and then, deploying it the way a toddler uses a new curse word — frequently, incorrectly, and with tremendous confidence. He mandates that every department "do AI immediately," without specifying into what, or why, or at what cost. Cost is for small minds. This is nothing short of *revolution*.

Then the invoice arrives.

Consider the cautionary tale of "Unber," a ride-hailing-adjacent startup whose leadership shall remain technically anonymous. Their Chief Visionary Officer — a real title they invented — pushed AI into everything. Customer support: AI. Internal memos: AI. The AI wrote other AI's performance reviews. Employees started routing grocery lists through the company's premium AI model because, as one put it, "nobody told us not to." The tokens flowed like an open bar at a wedding nobody was paying for.

The annual AI budget, generously provisioned to last twelve months, was exhausted in four. None knew how it happened.

Four months down the road, that's not a burn rate; that's a house fire. Somewhere in a data centre, a GPU / TPU was working so hard on someone's request to "make this email sound more confident" that it briefly achieved sentience, wept, and shut itself off.

And here is where the magic happens. The same executive who called AI "the electricity of our generation" now discovers that electricity, in fact, has a meter. Overnight, the guru becomes a prosecutor. "Why are we spending so much on this?" he demands, in a

meeting he scheduled specifically to demand it. "Who approved unlimited usage?" You did. In the all-hands. There's a slide. It has a brain on it.

The pivot is seamless and shameless. Yesterday's "AI-first company" is today's "we need to be thoughtful about AI." He starts using words like "ROI" and "guardrails" with the same misplaced confidence he once brought to "agentic." A committee is formed. The committee's first act is to draft a policy document — which someone secretly writes using the very AI they're now rationing.

The truth about Tokenomics is that AI was never free; it was just billed later, like every regret worth having. Whenever one is asking AI to do, the requests are broken down to tokens, roughly 4 characters makes a token, including a space or a dot, that is firing your work and which in turn brings out the result. The CXO wanted the future without reading the terms and conditions, and the terms and conditions, it turns out, are metered per thousand tokens. Or worse, enterprise usage which means it runs like a taxi, the more you run more it bills with no cap or alerts, unless one wants it. Larger the string of your questions, updates, changes, alteration requests make it even worse for one's pockets!

So, the brain slide gets quietly retired. The lapel mic goes back in the drawer. And somewhere, an industrial adhesives company returns to doing what it always did best — that is, until next quarter, when he discovers quantum computing.